



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Caution before consumption

Performance comes from discipline, not shortcuts. Supplements help only when **chosen wisely and used correctly.**

For 20 years, my work as a nutritionist has placed me inside locker rooms, training halls, doping control stations and the kitchens of athletes across disciplines. In these two decades, one concern has never faded: supplement safety. Recent data explains why this concern refuses to go away. According to the World Anti-Doping Agency's 2024 Testing Figures Report, India has ranked number one globally in Anti-Doping Rule Violations for three consecutive years.

Let me be very clear. There are two sides to India's doping crisis. The first is intentional misuse of banned substances. That is non-negotiable. It is unacceptable, and it deserves zero tolerance. But the second side is far more uncomfortable. Every year, I meet athletes who unknowingly consume contaminated, overdosed or entirely fake products. Some face devastating doping scares. Others pay with their gut health, hormones and years of hard work.

The Indian supplement market has grown at an extraordinary pace. Along with this growth, we now see counterfeits, mislabelled blends, banned stimulants, and spiked fat burners. On the athlete's side, there is pressure to recover faster, get stronger and keep up with global competition. This creates a dangerous intersection. The honest need for performance nutrition collides with a market that has grey areas, loopholes and inconsistent regulation. This is why supplement literacy is no longer optional.

The rise of contamination risks

Most doping violations in India involving supplements are not intentional. The modern anti-doping system can detect minute traces of substances such as steroids, stimulants and masking agents. So a contaminated protein powder or multivitamin can derail a clean athlete's career with as little as a few micrograms of a banned ingredient.

Over the years, I have analysed hundreds of supplement labels. I have seen products with banned ingredients hidden under obscure botanical names. I have

seen imported-looking packages that were printed in small shops with fake QR codes and poor-quality holograms. Many athletes assume a big tub and shiny label equals authenticity. Unfortunately, that is far from reality.

Several Indian studies have now confirmed widespread quality issues. These range from protein powders that deliver less than 50 per cent of their claimed protein to fat burners contaminated with stimulants that fall under the banned list.

Understanding the categories

Different supplements carry different levels of risk. Here is the general risk pattern I have observed:

Low risk: Evidence-based supplements such as whey isolate, creatine monohydrate, Omega-3 and basic vitamins, but only when sourced from transparent brands that publish batch testing.

Medium risk: Mass gainers, pre-workouts and intra-workouts. Many of these products use proprietary blends, strong stimulants or flavouring agents that may hide contaminants.

High risk: Imported-looking products without clear traceability, extreme fat burners, and testosterone boosters advertised for muscle gain.

How to verify authenticity

Athletes often ask me how to spot a fake product. In my experience, there are five practical steps every athlete should follow: